

Should purchasers/funders or control agencies insist that funded initiatives always have an impact evaluation?

Purchasers/funders that fund suppliers/providers often insist, either implicitly or explicitly, that initiatives do an impact evaluation. This sounds like a great idea. However, in practice, a blanket insistence on doing impact evaluation can waste evaluation resources that could be spent in better ways. It is undoubtedly always possible to do 'some' type of impact evaluation on an initiative. For instance, looking at the Impact Evaluation Design Types Tool (G8), you can almost always use an Intervention Logic (Theory-Based) Design. However, a funder needs to think about the credibility and value for money of such an impact evaluation design type (see the Impact Evaluation Feasibility Check (G9). Precious evaluation resources may be better spent on other types of evaluation. For instance, using an implementation evaluation to improve initiative implementation.

The most useful way for a funder to deal with impact evaluation is not to make a blanket demand that all initiatives do it. First, they may decide to fund an intensive evaluation of a pilot but not require impact evaluation from each instance of an initiative as it is rolled out. See the Full Initiative Roll-Out Versus Piloting Evaluation Explainer (G11). Second, a purchaser/funder can either themselves, or require initiatives to use the Impact Evaluation Suitability Check Tool (G9) to assess what impact evaluation, if any, is appropriate, feasible, affordable and credible for an initiative. The purchaser/funder can then decide whether it is best to spend money on impact evaluation or other types of evaluation or, alternatively, require little in the way of evaluation and simply get the initiative to report on its controllable indicators. (See the Types of Reporting and Accountability, a Control Agency or Funder Can Require From an Initiative Tool (E1)). This approach is consistent with the approach set out in the Strategic Evaluation Approach (G2).

This When Funders and Central Agencies Should Consider Alternatives to Impact Evaluation Checklist (G8) lists a set of questions about initiatives and the type of evaluation that should be used in each case. It can be used when doing 'evaluability assessment' - identifying if impact evaluation should be done.